BSIS Program Review

Kyle Potchka, Nov. 8, 2026

Introduction

I transferred to the University of South Florida and enrolled in the Bachelor of Science in Information Science (BSIS) program, with a concentration in Information Security. Before coming to USF, I attended Pasco-Hernando State College, where I earned my Associate of Arts degree in Spring 2024. My long-term goal is to work in cloud security because I believe cloud technologies will remain playing a major role in how organizations store and protect information. Across my time at USF, I have completed a variety of courses that helped me build both technical and professional skills. These courses and their associated assignments have prepared me for a future career in cybersecurity and information security.

Courses That Impacted Me

Many of the courses I completed at USF directly supported my career goals. Classes such as Information Behaviors, Information Policy, Policy Ethics, Security Policies, and Information Security Management taught me how organizations protect information while balancing legal, ethical, and business requirements. These courses helped me understand that cybersecurity is about more than technology; it also involves people, policies, and risk management.

One of the most useful courses for my future career was Networking and Communications. Because the course was built around Network+ concepts, it gave me a strong foundation in networking fundamentals, troubleshooting, and security. Learning how systems communicate across networks gave me a foundation that is essential for cybersecurity work.

I also enjoyed Architecting Operating Systems because of its hands-on approach. Each week, I worked in a virtual machine environment and completed labs focused on system administration and security. Rather than simply reading about concepts, I applied them directly, which helped me learn more effectively.

Outside of cybersecurity, courses such as Programming Concepts, Object-Oriented Programming, Database Concepts, Professional Writing, and Information Literacy helped build a well-rounded skill set. Even electives like Film & Culture, War and Society, and Happiness and Wellbeing contributed to my critical thinking and communication skills.

Significant Assignments

Assignments throughout the BSIS program let me apply what I learned in practical ways. One project that stands out was a sales-tracking application I created in Programming Concepts. This project challenged me to use programming logic and problem-solving skills to develop a solution for a realistic business scenario. It showed me how software can improve efficiency and automate tasks.

The labs in Architecting Operating Systems were another valuable learning experience. Through these assignments, I configured user accounts, managed permissions, applied security settings, and worked with tools such as PowerShell and Group Policy. These activities reinforced important security concepts and gave me experience with tasks commonly performed by IT and cybersecurity professionals.

One of the most meaningful projects I completed was my Self-Development Project for Information Security Management. For this project, I earned the Google Cybersecurity Professional Certificate. The certificate introduced me to topics such as Linux, SQL, Python, incident response, vulnerability management, risk assessment, and security operations. It connected many of the concepts I learned throughout the program and gave me a better understanding of what cybersecurity professionals do in real-world environments.

Conclusion

Looking back on my time in the BSIS program, I can see how much I have grown both technically and professionally. The program provided a strong foundation in networking, programming, operating systems, information security, and information management. More importantly, it taught me how these areas work together to protect organizations and their data.

The combination of coursework, hands-on labs, and professional development experiences has prepared me well for a future career in cybersecurity. As I continue pursuing opportunities in cloud security, I feel confident that the knowledge and skills I gained at USF will help me succeed in the field and continue growing as a cybersecurity professional.

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Grammarly, Inc. (n.d.). *Grammarly* [Computer software]. https://www.grammarly.com

Note: Grammarly was used to review grammar, spelling, and writing clarity while preparing this paper.